29 October 2026
Editor-in-Chief
Human Reproduction

Dear Editor-in-Chief,

Please consider our manuscript, "Reference-country composition and age-standardized PCOS-attributed infertility contrasts: China and 18 G20 countries, 1990–2023", as an Original Article.

We ask how changing country population shares within age contribute to a changing China-minus-international-reference difference in modeled PCOS-attributed infertility, even when age-standardization weights remain fixed. This informs the interpretation of pooled international benchmarks used in reproductive-health monitoring.

In GBD 2023 estimates for females aged 15–49, the total China-minus-18-country difference changed by +151.54 per 100,000 between 1990 and 2023. Established symmetric accounting allocated +88.65 to reference-country composition, +271.51 to Chinese rates and −208.62 to reference-country rates. Substituting UN WPP 2024 shares gave +86.76 for composition. Alternative benchmark definitions changed the sign of a near-zero secondary-infertility contrast in 2023.

Liu and colleagues' 2024 *Human Reproduction* study (doi:10.1093/humrep/dead241) examined burden and geographical trends. Our contribution addresses pooled-reference construction and reporting, rather than a new decomposition algorithm, clinical association or allegation that earlier national comparisons were erroneous. This exploratory aggregate analysis does not estimate causal effects, individual risk or treatment benefit. Confirmed jointly aligned GBD posterior draws were unavailable; derived uncertainty intervals are therefore not supplied. Code and aggregate results are available at an immutable public revision identified in the article; licensed GBD originals and restricted source-cell extracts are excluded.

OpenAI ChatGPT and Codex supported code development, analysis checks, drafting and technical editing under researcher-specified questions and revision instructions. The recorded model identifier for the documented Codex session on 29 October 2026 was `gpt-6.1-sol`; exact model versions for earlier separate ChatGPT sessions could not be independently verified and are not specified. No artificial observations or posterior draws replaced study data. The authors' final scientific review, verification of AI-supported content and approval remain to be confirmed before submission; human authors retain responsibility for the work.

XX: Corresponding author to confirm final author approval, authorship order, exclusive consideration, related manuscripts/preprints, funding and disclosures, and institutional ethics-review applicability before submission. These declarations have not been assumed on behalf of the authors.

Yours sincerely,
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